when called, simply add a field definition to the ever-accumulating set of names.

The definition of `decimal` also accepts a number of optional parameters, expressed as a hash.

To someone new to Ruby, this is a lot of heavy machinery thrown at solving such a simple problem. To someone familiar with Ruby, none of this machinery is particularly heavy. In any case, Rails makes extensive use of the facilities provided by Ruby to make defining operations (for example, migration tasks) as simple and as declarative as possible. Even small features of the language, such as optional parentheses and braces, contribute to the overall readability and ease of authoring.

Finally, a number of small features—or, rather, idiomatic combinations of features—are often not immediately obvious to people new to the Ruby language. We close this chapter with them.